

WEEK 15

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 31: 1 – 4; 2 Sam. 1: 1 – 16*

Death of Saul.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

Now the Philistines fought against Israel; and the men of Israel fled before the Philistines, and fell slain on Mount Gilbo'a. And the Philistines overtook Saul and his sons; and the Philistines slew Jonathan and Abin'adab and Mal'chishu'a, the sons of Saul. The battle pressed hard upon Saul, and the archers found him; and he was badly wounded by the archers. Then Saul said to his armour-bearer, "Draw your sword, and thrust me through with it, lest these uncircumcised come and thrust me through, and make sport of me." But his armour-bearer would not; for he feared greatly. Therefore Saul took his own sword, and fell upon it.

After the death of Saul, when David had returned from the slaughter of the Amal'ekites, David remained two days in Ziklag; and on the third day, behold, a man came from Saul's camp, with his clothes rent and earth upon his head. And when he came to David, he fell to the ground and did obeisance. David said to him, "Where do you come from?" And he said to him, "I have escaped from the camp of Israel." And David said to him, "How did it go? Tell me." And he answered, "The people have fled from the battle, and many of the people also have fallen and are dead; and Saul and his son Jonathan are also dead." Then David said to the young man who told him, "How do you know that Saul and his son Jonathan are dead?" And the young man who told him said, "By chance I happened to be on Mount Gilbo'a; and there was Saul leaning upon his spear; and lo, the chariots and the horsemen were close upon him. And when he looked behind him, he saw me, and called to me. And I answered, 'Here I am.' And he said to me, 'Who are you?' I answered him, 'I am an Amal'ekite.' And he said to me, 'Stand beside me and slay me; for anguish has seized me, and yet my life still lingers.' So I stood beside him, and slew him, because I was sure that he could not live after he had fallen; and I took the crown which was on his

head and the armlet which was on his arm, and I have brought them here to my lord."

Then David took hold of his clothes, and rent them; and so did all the men who were with him; and they mourned and wept and fasted until evening for Saul and for Jonathan his son and for the people of the LORD and for the house of Israel, because they had fallen by the sword. And David said to the young man who told him, "Where do you come from?" And he answered, "I am the son of a sojourner, an Amal'ekite." David said to him, "How is it you were not afraid to put forth your hand to destroy the LORD'S anointed?" Then David called one of the young men and said, "Go, fall upon him." And he smote him so that he died. And David said to him, "Your blood be upon your head; for your own mouth has testified against you, saying, 'I have slain the LORD'S anointed.'"

Responsorial. *Cfr. 2 Sam. 1: 21, 19*

R: Mountains of Gilboa, may no rain fall on you, * because here the heroes of Israel have fallen.

V: All the mountains around have seen the Lord; but they will not look at Gilboa anymore.

R: because here the heroes of Israel have fallen.

Second Reading. *Disc. 47: 1, 2, 3, 6*

He is our God and we are the people of His pasture.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Augustine, bishop.

The words we have sung contain our confession that we are God's sheep: 'He is the Lord our God who made us. He is our God and we are the people who belong to his pasture, the flock that is led by his hand'. Human shepherds have not made their sheep themselves, did not themselves create the sheep that they feed. But the Lord our God, because he is God and Creator, made the sheep that he possesses and feeds. No one else made those that he feeds, nor does another feed those that he made.

We have professed in this canticle that we are his sheep, the people of his pasture, the sheep of his flock. Let us therefore listen to what he tells us as his sheep. Formerly he was speaking to the shepherds, but now he is speaking to the sheep. We listened to those words of his with trembling, whereas you listened with peace of mind. What about those words he

speaks today? Surely it is now our turn to listen with peace of mind, while you tremble? No. In the first place, because even if we are shepherds, the shepherd does not listen with trembling only to what is said to the shepherds, but also to what is said to the sheep. If a man listens unbothered to what is said to the sheep, he has no thought for his sheep. Secondly, we have already told you that two things are to be borne in mind, first that we are Christians, and secondly, that we have been put in charge of you. Because we are leaders, we are ranked among the shepherds- if we are good. As Christians, on the other hand, we too are sheep like you. So whether the Lord is speaking to the shepherds or to the sheep, we must listen with trembling to everything he says, nor must our hearts be free from anxiety.

Let us hear, then, my brothers, how the Lord reproaches the bad sheep, and what promises he makes to those that are his own. 'You are my sheep', he says. First, if one thinks about the happiness of being God's flock, my brethren, it brings great joy even amidst our tears and troubles. For the one of whom it was said: 'He who keeps Israel will neither slumber nor sleep', also heard the words, 'You are the shepherd of Israel'. He watches over us when we are awake, he watches over us too when we are asleep. If a man's flock feels safe with its human shepherd, what security ought we to feel when our shepherd is God, not only because he feeds us but also because he made us.

'As for you my flock', he says, 'thus says the Lord God: Behold I judge between sheep and sheep, rams and goats'. What are goats doing here in God's flock? In the same pastures, at the same springs, the goats destined for God's left hand mingle with those destined for the right; those who will be separated are first tolerated. Here the sheep exercise patience like God's patience. He will make the division: some will go to the left, and others to the right.

Responsorial. *Jn. 10: 27-28; Ez. 34: 15*

R: My own sheep listen to my voice; I know them and they follow me. I give them eternal life, and they shall never perish; * no one shall snatch them from my care.

V: I myself will tend my flock, I myself will pen them in their fold;

R: No one shall snatch them from my care.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jb. 1: 1 – 22*

Job is deprived of his goods.

A reading from the book of Job.

There was a man in the land of Uz, whose name was Job; and that man was blameless and upright, one who feared God, and turned away from evil. There were born to him seven sons and three daughters. He had seven thousand sheep, three thousand camels, five hundred yoke of oxen, and five hundred she-asses, and very many servants; so that this man was the greatest of all the people of the east.

His sons used to go and hold a feast in the house of each on his day; and they would send and invite their three sisters to eat and drink with them. And when the days of the feast had run their course, Job would send and sanctify them, and he would rise early in the morning and offer burnt offerings according to the number of them all; for Job said, "It may be that my sons have sinned, and cursed God in their hearts." Thus Job did continually.

Now there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came among them. The LORD said to Satan, "Whence have you come?" Satan answered the LORD, "From going to and fro on the earth, and from walking up and down on it." And the LORD said to Satan, "Have you considered my servant Job, that there is none like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, who fears God and turns away from evil?" Then Satan answered the LORD, "Does Job fear God for nought? Have you not put a hedge about him and his house and all that he has, on every side? You have blessed the work of his hands, and his possessions have increased in the land. But put forth your hand now, and touch all that he has, and he will curse you to your face." And the LORD

said to Satan, "Behold, all that he has is in your power; only upon himself do not put forth your hand." So Satan went forth from the presence of the LORD.

Now there was a day when his sons and daughters were eating and drinking wine in their eldest brother's house; and there came a messenger to Job, and said, "The oxen were ploughing and the asses feeding beside them; and the Sabe'ans fell upon them and took them, and slew the servants with the edge of the sword; and I alone have escaped to tell you." While he was yet speaking, there came another, and said, "The fire of God fell from heaven and burned up the sheep and the servants, and consumed them; and I alone have escaped to tell you." While he was yet speaking, there came another, and said, "The Chalde'ans formed three companies, and made a raid upon the camels and took them, and slew the servants with the edge of the sword; and I alone have escaped to tell you."

While he was yet speaking, there came another, and said, "Your sons and daughters were eating and drinking wine in their eldest brother's house; and behold, a great wind came across the wilderness, and struck the four corners of the house, and it fell upon the young people, and they are dead; and I alone have escaped to tell you."

Then Job arose, and rent his robe, and shaved his head, and fell upon the ground, and worshiped.

And he said, "Naked I came from my mother's womb, and naked shall I return; the LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD." In all this Job did not sin or charge God with wrong.

Responsorial. *Jb. 2: 10; 1: 21*

R: If we accept good from God: should we not accept evil also? * The Lord has given, the Lord has taken away; blessed be the name of the Lord.

V: Naked I came out of my mother's womb, and naked I will return.

R: The Lord has given, the Lord has taken away, blessed be the name of the Lord.

Second Reading. *Hom. On the paralytic lowered through the roof.*

A certain example of patience.

A reading from the "Homilies" of St. John Chrysostom, bishop.

Not only from the New, but also from the Old Testament can we draw comfort. When we hear that Job, after having lost his fortune, after the death of his herds, lost not one or two or three sons, but all of them and in the full bloom of their life; in front of such strength of soul, even if you were the weakest of all, you can console yourself and take courage with ease.

You at least, o man, have been able to assist your sick son, to see him bed ridden, to listen to his last words and to be present at his last breath; you have lowered his eyelids and closed his mouth: he instead was not present when they gave up the spirit and drew their last breath, all of them were buried as if in one unique tomb in the midst of the walls of their house. Yet after so many and such great disasters he did not cry, he did not bear animosity, but what did he say? “The Lord has given, the Lord has taken back, blessed be the name of the Lord!” (Jb. 1: 21).

Let us also say this in every misfortune that happens to us: in the loss of money, in the physical sickness, in insults, in calumnies, in every other human disgrace, let us repeat: “The Lord has given, the Lord has taken away, blessed be the name of the Lord!”

If we convince ourselves of this reality, we will never suffer again any evil and even if a thousand misfortunes were to befall us, we would have more gain than loss; from these words will come to you many good things rather than evils, because they will render you favourable to God and you will destroy the lordship of the enemy.

As soon as in fact the tongue pronounces these words, the devil immediately goes far away from him: and if he goes away, also the sadness is reduced, and with it the worries that afflict us; thus, other than the joys of this life, you will have also those which are reserved for us in heaven. You have a splendid example in Job and in the apostles, who having despised the evils of this life for God, have gained the eternal goods.

Let us follow therefore their example and in all the events that happen to us let us give thanks to the good God: thus we will run with happiness along the way of this life and we will possess the future goods, through the grace and goodness of our Lord Jesus Christ, to whom be glory and dominion now and forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Jam. 5: 11; Jdt. 8: 17*

R: Look, we call blessed those who have persevered. * You also be patient, reassure your hearts, because the coming of the Lord is near.

V: Therefore we await with faith the salvation that comes from him.

R: You also be patient, reassure your hearts, because the coming of the Lord is near.

YEAR A

Gospel. *Mt. 13: 1-23*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

That same day Jesus went out of the house and sat beside the sea. Such great crowds gathered around him that he got into a boat and sat there, while the whole crowd stood on the beach.

And he told them many things in parables, saying: "Listen! A sower went out to sow. And as he sowed, some seeds fell on the path, and the birds came and ate them up. Other seeds fell on rocky ground, where they did not have much soil, and they sprang up quickly, since they had no depth of soil. But when the sun rose, they were scorched; and since they had no root, they withered away. Other seeds fell among thorns, and the thorns grew up and choked them. Other seeds fell on good soil and brought forth grain, some a hundredfold, some sixty, some thirty. Let anyone with ears listen!"

Then the disciples came and asked him, "Why do you speak to them in parables?" He answered, "To you it has been given to know the secrets of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it has not been given. For to those who have, more will be given, and they will have abundance; but from those who have nothing, even what they have will be taken away. The reason I speak to them in parables is that 'seeing they do not perceive, and hearing they do not listen, nor do they understand.' With them indeed is fulfilled the prophecy of Isaiah that says: 'You will indeed listen, but never understand, and you will indeed look, but never perceive. For this people's heart has grown dull, and their ears are hard of hearing, and they have shut their eyes; so that they might not look with their eyes, and listen with their ears, and understand with their heart and turn-- and I would heal them.' But blessed are your eyes, for they see, and your ears, for they hear. Truly I tell you,

many prophets and righteous people longed to see what you see, but did not see it, and to hear what you hear, but did not hear it.

"Hear then the parable of the sower. When anyone hears the word of the kingdom and does not understand it, the evil one comes and snatches away what is sown in the heart; this is what was sown on the path. As for what was sown on rocky ground, this is the one who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy; yet such a person has no root, but endures only for a while, and when trouble or persecution arises on account of the word, that person immediately falls away. As for what was sown among thorns, this is the one who hears the word, but the cares of the world and the lure of wealth choke the word, and it yields nothing. But as for what was sown on good soil, this is the one who hears the word and understands it, who indeed bears fruit and yields, in one case a hundredfold, in another sixty, and in another thirty."

Third Reading. *Nn. 2, 3, 4*

Man must sow, God gives the produce.

A reading from the "Homily on the seed" of St. Athanasius, bishop.

The Lord passed through the fields that had been sown; the grain of wheat passed through the harvests; he was that spiritual grain that fell in a place alone and rising fecundated the entire world, and of which he himself said: "If the wheat of grain that falls to the ground does not die, it remains alone; if instead it dies it produces much fruit" (Jn. 12: 24).

Jesus therefore passed through those who had been sown: he who one day would be the grain of wheat to nourish life, for now was the sower, as it is written in the gospel: "Behold, the sower went out to sow" (Mt. 13: 3).

Jesus spread with abundance the seed, but the quantity of the fruit depends on the nature of the soil. Where in fact the soil is rocky, the seed easily dries up; not because of its own weakness, but because of the fault of the earth, because the seed has vital strength, but the earth is sterile not having depth. If the earth does not retain humidity, the rays of the sun penetrating with greater force, dry up the seed: not therefore because of any defect of the seed, but because of the fault of the earth.

The seed is spread also over the earth covered with thorns, and the seed is always fertile; but the brambles suffocate it and the external obstruction does not permit it to develop its intrinsic strength. If then the seed falls on good soil, it produces fruit differently: some thirty, some sixty, some hundred fold. The nature of the seed is identical, but the fruit is different and the spiritual results of those who are instructed are different. The sower went out therefore to sow and in part he worked personally, in part through his disciples. Thus it is written in the Acts of the Apostles, after the stoning of Stephen: "All of them were dispersed" (Act. 8: 11); not put to flight because of their weakness and neither separated in faith, but dispersed: becoming the wheat by virtue of the sower, transformed into heavenly bread by the doctrine of life their efficacy was spread everywhere.

He who sows the truth; Jesus, the Only begotten Son of God, passed through the fields, spreading by the command of the Father not only the seed, but also teachings that were dense with marvellous doctrine.

Certainly those seeds were destined to fulfil great works.

Let us now speak of the earth in the time of the sowing and of the shoots that the seed produces in spring, not to deal with it scientifically, but in order to adore the author of such wonders. Men, fulfilling their work, subject the oxen to the plough, they plough the land making the surface softer so that the rain does not flow away, but, penetrating deeply, will make an abundant harvest grow. The seeds, thrown on the earth that is thus prepared, find a double advantage: first, the depth and the friability of the earth; second, they remain hidden from the birds. But the man, even though he does what is in his power, cannot produce fruit. Man must sow, but it is God who gives growth. When therefore the seed begins to form the stem and grows, from the ear its fruit is known, if it is grain or darnel. Have you understood what has been read: It is now for me to lead you to more spiritual things. Through the apostles Jesus planted the good news of the kingdom of heaven on the earth.

He who has welcomed the preaching, keeps it in himself until it produces the shoot, and therefore he assiduously attends the Church. And here we gather together bearing one wheat the other darnel, that is both the faithful as well as the hypocrites come, so that that which has been read can be clearer. And we the farmers of the Church work the earth with the hoe of the preaching and we cultivate the field in a way that it produces fruit; yet we do not know the condition of the earth, in as much the similarity of the

leaves often deceive the farmer. But when the doctrine is transformed into action and the fruit of labour is manifested, then it is made clear who is the faithful and who is the hypocrite.

Responsorial. *Gal. 6: 9-10; Wis. 3: 15*

R: Let us not become weary in doing good, for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up. * Therefore as we have opportunity, let us do good to all people, especially to those who belong to the family of believers.

V: The fruit of good works is glorious.

R: Therefore as we have opportunity, let us do good to all people, especially to those who belong to the family of believers.

YEAR B

Gospel. *Mk. 6: 7-13*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Mark.

He called the twelve and began to send them out two by two, and gave them authority over the unclean spirits. He ordered them to take nothing for their journey except a staff; no bread, no bag, no money in their belts; but to wear sandals and not to put on two tunics. He said to them, "Wherever you enter a house, stay there until you leave the place. If any place will not welcome you and they refuse to hear you, as you leave, shake off the dust that is on your feet as a testimony against them." So they went out and proclaimed that all should repent. They cast out many demons, and anointed with oil many who were sick and cured them.

Third Reading. *Hom. 17: 5-8*

The service of preaching.

A reading from the "Homilies on the Gospel" of St. Gregory the Great, pope.

"Do not carry a purse, or bag, nor sandals and do not greet anyone along the way" (Lk. 10: 4). The preacher must have a lot of faith in God in order to be sure that, though not worrying about the present life, he will

certainly not lack anything; and this so that turning his thoughts to material things, he will not neglect to provide the heavenly realities to the others.

The peace offered by the preacher remains in the house if there is a son of peace in that house, if not it will return to the preacher, because, either there will be someone who is predestined for eternal life, who listening to the divine word puts it into practise, or, if no one would want to listen to it, the preacher will not remain without fruit, because the peace returns to him in so much as the Lord will reward his work for the effort sustained.

It is for this therefore that the Lord prohibits them to carry purse or haversack, while he grants the means of livelihood through the preaching itself: “Remain in that house, eating and drinking that which they have, because the labourer deserves his wages” (Lk. 10: 7). If your peace is welcomed, it is right that you remain in the same house eating and drinking of that which they have, in order to have an earthly remuneration from those to whom we offer the goods of the heavenly Father. The wages then that we receive in the present life should help us to stretch out with greater energy towards the future wage. For this an elderly preacher must not preach in order to receive the reward on this earth, but in order to have the strength to continue to preach.

In fact whoever preaches in order to receive down here praise or gifts, without any doubt deprives himself of the eternal reward. He then who preaches desiring to please men in order to attract them with his words to love towards the Lord and not towards himself, or receives a remuneration in order not to be exhausted because of poverty, will certainly receive his reward in the heavenly homeland because during his life he has received only what was necessary.

But what should we do, O Shepherd, we who receive a reward and we are not even labourers? We receive also from the income of the holy Church as a daily payment, yet we do not tire ourselves out to preach for the eternal Church. Let us think of what reason of condemnation will be this having received the reward of the work without having worked for it. Look, we live on the offering of the faithful, but what toil do we sustain for their souls? We receive as a remuneration that which the faithful have offered in remission for their sins, and yet we do not toil as it would be, just to pray and to preach against the same sins.

Responsorial. *2 Cor. 12: 14-15; Phil. 2: 17*

R: I do not desire your goods, but you. After all children should not have to save up for their parents, but parents for their children. So I will very gladly spend for you everything that I have * And I will expend myself for your souls.

V: Even if my blood has to be poured out in libation on the sacrifice and on the offering of your faith, I am glad;

R: and I will expend myself for your souls.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 10: 25-37*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

Just then a lawyer stood up to test Jesus. "Teacher," he said, "what must I do to inherit eternal life?" He said to him, "What is written in the law? What do you read there?" He answered, "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your strength, and with all your mind; and your neighbour as yourself." And he said to him, "You have given the right answer; do this, and you will live."

But wanting to justify himself, he asked Jesus, "And who is my neighbour?" Jesus replied, "A man was going down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell into the hands of robbers, who stripped him, beat him, and went away, leaving him half dead. Now by chance a priest was going down that road; and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side. So likewise a Levite, when he came to the place and saw him, passed by on the other side. But a Samaritan while travelling came near him; and when he saw him, he was moved with pity. He went to him and bandaged his wounds, having poured oil and wine on them. Then he put him on his own animal, brought him to an inn, and took care of him. The next day he took out two denarii, gave them to the innkeeper, and said, 'Take care of him; and when I come back, I will repay you whatever more you spend.' Which of these three, do you think, was a neighbour to the man who fell into the hands of the robbers?" He said, "The one who showed him mercy." Jesus said to him, "Go and do likewise."

Third Reading . *Hom. 10, 4*

Let us learn to take care of everyone in the same way.

A reading from the “Homilies on the Letter to the Hebrews” of St. John Chrysostom, bishop

Every believer is a saint: by the fact that he is a believer he is a saint, even if he lives in the world. Therefore, if we see a man of the world in difficulty let us help him. We must not show ourselves solicitous only to those who dwell on the heights: those are holy by life and by faith; these others instead are also holy through faith, and many are also by their life. Let it not happen that if we see a monk in prison we visit him, and if instead it deals with a layperson, we ignore him: this one is also a saint and a brother. And what should we do, you will say, if he was perhaps a reprobate, a wicked person? Listen to Christ who says: “Do not judge, in order not to be judged” (Mt. 7: 1).

You act for God. What do I say? Even if you were to see a pagan in difficulty you must help him, in a word, it is a duty to help every man to whom a misfortune happens, much more a lay believer. Listen to Paul who says: “Let us do good towards all, above all towards the brothers in the faith” (Gal. 6: 10). He in fact who tries to benefit only the hermits and who says, examining him with curiosity: “If he is not worthy, if he is not just, if he does not do miracles I will not help him” has already subtracted a lot from the almsgiving, and on the contrary, gradually he will subtract the rest also.

That which is done towards the sinners and the guilty is also almsgiving. Almsgiving in fact is to have compassion not for those who have done good, but for those who have sinned. And in order to be convinced, listen to the parable of Christ, who says: “A man went down from Jerusalem to Jericho and he fell into the hands of brigands...” (Lk. 10: 30), who after having beaten him left him on the road wounded and half dead. A Levite came by chance and, seeing him, passed by. In the same way a priest came, saw him, and passed by on the other side. Finally a Samaritan came by and took great care of him, he bound his wounds, poured oil over them, put him on his ass, and brought him to the inn and said to the innkeeper: “Take care of him”. And, look what great generosity: “And when I return, I will reimburse you for any extra expense you may have.”

After having narrated this, Jesus asks: Who therefore is his neighbour? And the doctor of the law, who had answered: “The one who had compassion on him”, hears said: “Go and you also do the same” (Lk. 10:

37). Reflect on this parable. Jesus does not say that a Jew had done this to a Samaritan, but that a Samaritan had shown such generosity. From here we learn that we should care for all in the same way, and not only for the brothers of faith, neglecting the others. So also you, if you see someone suffering, do not stop to investigate: he has the right to your help for the simple fact that he suffers. If in fact you pull up a donkey that is in danger of suffocating from the well, without caring about who it belongs to, much more is it a duty not to investigate too much who is that man: he is of God, be he Greek, be he Jew, even if he is a pagan, he needs your help.

Responsorial. *1 Th. 5: 14, 15, 18; Rm. 15: 7*

R: Sustain the weak, search always for the good among yourselves and with all. * This is in fact the will of God in Christ Jesus towards you.

V: Welcome one another as Christ welcomes you, for the glory of God.

R: This is in fact the will of God in Christ Jesus towards you.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Sam. 2: 1 – 11; 3: 1- 5*

David is consecrated king of Judah and Hebron.

A reading from the second book of Samuel.

After this David inquired of the LORD, "Shall I go up into any of the cities of Judah?" And the LORD said to him, "Go up." David said, "To which shall I go up?" And he said, "To Hebron." So David went up there, and his two wives also, Ahin'o-am of Jezreel, and Ab'igail the widow of Nabal of Carmel. And David brought up his men who were with him, every one with his household; and they dwelt in the towns of Hebron. And the men of Judah came, and there they anointed David king over the house of Judah.

When they told David, "It was the men of Ja'bish-gil'ead who buried Saul," David sent messengers to the men of Ja'bish-gil'ead, and said to them, "May you be blessed by the LORD, because you showed this loyalty to Saul your lord, and buried him! Now may the LORD show steadfast love and faithfulness to you! And I will do good to you because you have done this thing. Now therefore let your hands be strong, and be valiant; for Saul your lord is dead, and the house of Judah has anointed me king over them."

Now Abner the son of Ner, commander of Saul's army, had taken Ish-bo'sheth the son of Saul, and brought him over to Mahana'im; and he made him king over Gilead and the Ash'urites and Jezreel and E'phraim and Benjamin and all Israel. Ish-bo'sheth, Saul's son, was forty years old when he began to reign over Israel, and he reigned two years. But the house of Judah followed David. And the time that David was king in Hebron over the house of Judah was seven years and six months.

There was a long war between the house of Saul and the house of David; and David grew stronger and stronger, while the house of Saul became weaker and weaker.

And sons were born to David at Hebron: his first-born was Amnon, of Ahin'o-am of Jezreel; and his second, Chil'e-ab, of Ab'igail the widow of Nabal of Carmel; and the third, Ab'salom the son of Ma'acah the daughter of Talmai king of Geshur; and the fourth, Adoni'jah the son of Haggith; and

the fifth, Shephati'ah the son of Abi'tal; and the sixth, Ith're-am, of Eglah, David's wife. These were born to David in Hebron.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Gen. 49: 10, 8*

R: The sceptre of Judah will not be taken away from him, nor the rod of command from between his feet, * until he to whom the obedience of the nations is due, comes.

V: Judah, your brothers will praise you, in front of you the sons of your father will fall prostrate.

R: until he to whom the obedience of the nations is due, comes.

Second Reading. *Disc. 47: 12 – 14*

If I please men, I will not be a servant of Christ anymore.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Augustine, bishop.

‘Our boast is this: the testimony of our conscience’. There are men who judge rashly, men who disparage, talebearers, grumblers, men who try to guess what they do not see and to gossip about what they do not even suspect. What defence have we left against such men, except the testimony of our own conscience? For indeed, my brothers, even with those whom we want to please, we do not seek our glory, nor ought we to seek it, but their salvation; so that if we walk in the right path, they will not go astray by following us. Let them imitate us if we imitate Christ; if we are not imitators of Christ, let them imitate him. For he feeds his flock, and he alone is with all who feed as they should, for all are in him.

We do not then seek our own interests when we seek to please men, but we wish to delight in men, we rejoice that what is good pleases them- for their good, not our honour. It is clear against whom the apostle said: ‘If I sought to please men I should not be the servant of Christ’. And it is evident on whose account he said: ‘Please all men in everything as I please all in everything’. Both statements are clear, both are pure, both are calm, neither is confused. Just eat and drink, do not trample down the pasture or muddy the water.

You have certainly heard those words of the Lord Jesus Christ himself, the Master of the apostles: ‘Let your works so shine before men, that they may see your good deeds, and give glory to your Father who is in heaven’, that is, who made you as you are. ‘For we are the people who belong to his

pasture, the flock that is led by his hand'. So let him be praised who made you good, if you are good, not you who by yourself could only be bad. Why do you want to twist the truth round, so that when you do something bad, you want the Lord to be blamed? For he who said: 'Let your works shine before men', also said in the same sermon: 'Beware of practising your piety before men'. As these things seemed to you to be contradictory on the lips of the apostles, so too in the gospel. If, however, you do not muddy the water of your heart, you will recognize the harmony of the scriptures, and you will be at peace with them.

Let us take care then, my brothers, not only to live well, but also to conduct ourselves well before men; let us try not only to have a good conscience, but- as far as our weakness is able, as far as the vigilance of our human frailty allows it – let us see to it that nothing we do shall cause a weaker brother to have evil suspicion. We must take care that, while eating pure herbage and drinking pure water, we do not perhaps trample down God's pasture, so that the weak sheep have to eat what has been trampled on and drink what has been muddied.

Responsorial. *Phil. 2: 2, 3-4; 1 Th. 5: 14-15*

R: Fill up my cup of happiness by thinking and feeling alike, loving one another equally, humbly reckoning others better than yourselves. * Look to each other's interest and not merely to your own.

V: Support the weak and be very patient with them all, always aiming at doing the best you can for each other and for all men.

R: Look to each other's interest and not merely to your own.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jb. 2: 1 – 13*

Job completely covered by sores, is visited by his friends.

A reading from the book of Job.

Again there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came among them to present

himself before the LORD. And the LORD said to Satan, "Whence have you come?" Satan answered the LORD, "From going to and fro on the earth, and from walking up and down on it." And the LORD said to Satan, "Have you considered my servant Job, that there is none like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, who fears God and turns away from evil? He still holds fast his integrity, although you moved me against him, **to destroy him without cause.**" Then Satan answered the LORD, "Skin for skin! All that a man has he will give for his life. But put forth your hand now, and touch his bone and his flesh, and he will curse you to your face." And the LORD said to Satan, "Behold, he is in your power; only spare his life."

So Satan went forth from the presence of the LORD, and afflicted Job with loathsome sores from the sole of his foot to the crown of his head. And he took a potsherd with which to scrape himself, and sat among the ashes. Then his wife said to him, "Do you still hold fast your integrity? Curse God, and die." But he said to her, "You speak as one of the foolish women would speak. Shall we receive good at the hand of God, and shall we not receive evil?" In all this Job did not sin with his lips.

Now when Job's three friends heard of all this evil that had come upon him, they came each from his own place, Eli'phaz the Te'manite, Bildad the Shuhite, and Zophar the Na'amathite. They made an appointment together to come to condole with him and comfort him. And when they saw him from afar, they did not recognize him; and they raised their voices and wept; and they rent their robes and sprinkled dust upon their heads toward heaven. And they sat with him on the ground seven days and seven nights, and no one spoke a word to him, for they saw that his suffering was very great.

Responsorial. Ps. 37: 2, 3, 4, 12

R: Lord, do not punish me in your indignation. Your arrows have pierced me; * because of your indignation there is nothing in me that is healthy.

V: My friends stand aside from my wounds, my neighbours stay far away;

R: because of your indignation there is nothing in me that is healthy.

Second Reading. Book. 3: 15 – 16

*If from God we accept good,
why should we not accept evil as well?*

A reading from the “Commentary of the book of Job” of St. Gregory the Great, pope.

When Paul contemplated in himself the riches of spiritual wisdom, yet saw himself outwardly a corruptible body, he said: ‘We have this treasure in earthen vessels’. Thus, with blessed Job, the earthen vessel felt those gaping sores on his body, but this treasure remained entire within. Outwardly, his wounds gaped, but the treasure of wisdom did not fail to well up within him and issue forth in words of holy instruction: ‘Shall we receive good at the hand of God, and not receive evil? By good, he meant either the temporal or the eternal gifts of God; and by evil, he denoted the inflictions of the present time, of which the Lord said, through the Prophet, ‘I am the Lord, and there is no other. I form the light, and create darkness; I make peace, and create evil’.

‘I form the light and create darkness’: for when the darkness of pain is created by blows received from outside ourselves, the light of the mind is kindled by instruction within. ‘I make peace, and create evil’: for peace with God is restored in us when the things that, rightly created yet wrongly desired, turn into the kind of scourges that we regard as ‘evil’. We have grown at variance with God through sin. Therefore it is fitting that we should be brought back to peace with him by the scourge, so that as every being, created good, turns to pain for us, so the mind of chastened man may, in a humbled state, be made new in peace with the creator.

We should especially notice the skilful turn of reflection with which he gathers himself up to meet the persuasions of his wife, saying, ‘Shall we receive good at the hand of God, and not receive evil?’ For it is a mighty solace of our tribulation if, when we suffer affliction, we call to mind our Maker’s gifts to us. Nor will painful things depress us, if we recall in time the gifts that cheer us. For it is written, ‘In the day of prosperity, adversity is forgotten, and in the day of adversity, prosperity is not remembered’.

He who receives God’s gifts, and at the time he receives them forgets to fear possible affliction, is brought low by this presumptuous joy. And he who is bruised by scourges and yet, in the season of scourging neglects to comfort himself with the gifts which it has been his lot to receive, is thrown out of his steadfastness of mind by despair on every hand.

The two must be united, so that each may always have the other’s support; then the remembrance of the gift may moderate the pain of

affliction, and misgiving and dread of affliction may bite down the joyousness of receiving. Thus the holy man, to soothe the depression of his mind amidst the wounds, weighs the sweetness of receiving against the pains of affliction, saying, 'Shall we receive good at the hand of God and not receive evil?'

Responsorial. *Jb. 2: 10; 1: 21-22*

R: If we take happiness from God's hand, must we not take sorrow too? *
The Lord gave, the Lord has taken back. Blessed be the name of the Lord!

V: In all this misfortune Job committed no sin nor offered any insult to God.

R: The Lord gave, the Lord has taken back. Blessed be the name of the Lord!

Gospel. *Mt. 10: 34 – 11. 1*

I have not come to bring peace but the sword.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"Do not think that I have come to bring peace on earth; I have not come to bring peace, but a sword. For I have come to set a man against his father, and a daughter against her mother, and a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law; and a man's foes will be those of his own household.

He who loves father or mother more than me is not worthy of me; and he who loves son or daughter more than me is not worthy of me; and he who does not take his cross and follow me is not worthy of me. He who finds his life will lose it, and he who loses his life for my sake will find it. "He who receives you receives me, and he who receives me receives him who sent me. He who receives a prophet because he is a prophet shall receive a prophet's reward, and he who receives a righteous man because he is a righteous man shall receive a righteous man's reward. And whoever gives to one of these little ones even a cup of cold water because he is a disciple, truly, I say to you, he shall not lose his reward."

And when Jesus had finished instructing his twelve disciples, he went on from there to teach and preach in their cities.

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Sam. 4: 2 – 5: 7*

David, king of all Israel, conquers Jerusalem.

A reading from the second book of Samuel.

Now Saul's son had two men who were captains of raiding bands; the name of the one was Ba'anah, and the name of the other Rechab, sons of Rimmon a man of Benjamin from Be-er'oth (for Be-er'oth also is reckoned to Benjamin; the Be-er'othites fled to Gitta'im, and have been sojourners there to this day.

Jonathan, the son of Saul, had a son who was crippled in his feet. He was five years old when the news about Saul and Jonathan came from Jezreel; and his nurse took him up, and fled; and, as she fled in her haste, he fell, and became lame. And his name was Mephib'osheth.

Now the sons of Rimmon the Be-er'othite, Rechab and Ba'anah, set out, and about the heat of the day they came to the house of Ish-bo'sheth, as he was taking his noonday rest. And behold, the doorkeeper of the house had been cleaning wheat, but she grew drowsy and slept; so Rechab and Ba'anah his brother slipped in. When they came into the house, as he lay on his bed in his bedchamber, they smote him, and slew him, and beheaded him. They took his head, and went by the way of the Arabah all night, and brought the head of Ish-bo'sheth to David at Hebron. And they said to the king, "Here is the head of Ish-bo'sheth, the son of Saul, your enemy, who sought your life; the LORD has avenged my lord the king this day on Saul and on his offspring." But David answered Rechab and Ba'anah his brother, the sons of Rimmon the Be-er'othite, "As the LORD lives, who has redeemed my life out of every adversity, when one told me, 'Behold, Saul is dead,' and thought he was bringing good news, I seized him and slew him at Ziklag, which was the reward I gave him for his news. How much more, when wicked men have slain a righteous man in his own house upon his bed, shall I not now require his blood at your hand, and destroy you from the earth?" And David commanded his young men, and they killed them, and cut off their hands and feet, and hanged them beside the pool at Hebron.

But they took the head of Ish-bo'sheth, and buried it in the tomb of Abner at Hebron.

Then all the tribes of Israel came to David at Hebron, and said, "Behold, we are your bone and flesh. In times past, when Saul was king over us, it was you that led out and brought in Israel; and the LORD said to you, `You shall be shepherd of my people Israel, and you shall be prince over Israel.'" So all the elders of Israel came to the king at Hebron; and King David made a covenant with them at Hebron before the LORD, and they anointed David king over Israel. David was thirty years old when he began to reign, and he reigned forty years. At Hebron he reigned over Judah seven years and six months; and at Jerusalem he reigned over all Israel and Judah thirty-three years.

And the king and his men went to Jerusalem against the Jeb'usites, the inhabitants of the land, who said to David, "You will not come in here, but the blind and the lame will ward you off" -- thinking, "David cannot come in here." Nevertheless David took the stronghold of Zion, that is, the city of David.

Responsorial. *Ps. 2: 2, 6, 1*

R: The kings of the earth rise, the princes plot together against the Lord and against his Messiah. * I have constituted him sovereign on Sion, my holy mountain.

V. Why do the nations conspire? Why do the peoples plot in vain?

R: I have constituted him sovereign on Sion, my holy mountain.

Second Reading. *C. 30: 1 – 5*

Your kingdom come.

A reading from the book “The way of perfection” of St. Theresa of Avila, virgin and doctor of the Church.

Is there anyone, however ill mannered, who would not consider beforehand how to address a person of high rank of whom it was necessary to ask a favour? Would not one be careful to gratify him, to avoid offending him, and to think over what one meant to petition for, and what use could be made of it, especially if the request were an important one, such as the good Jesus tells us to beg for? I think this point deserves serious consideration.

Could you not, O my Lord, have included everything in one phrase, saying: 'Give us, Father, whatever we need'? For, as God knows all things, further words seem needless. O eternal Wisdom! This alone would have sufficed between you and your Father. Thus did you address him in the garden: you showed him your will and your dread, and submitted yourself to his will. But you know, O my God, that we are not so resigned as you were to the will of your Father- there was need to name each thing we pray for, that we might decide whether it was what we wanted, and otherwise not to ask it of you. For being what we are, unless what we want is given to us, as we have free will we should not accept it as the gift of God though it might be best for us, since unless we see the money in our hand we never think we are rich.

The good Jesus bids us say these words that ask that his kingdom may come in us: 'Hallowed be your name; your kingdom come in us'. How great is the wisdom of our Master. It is well that we should all learn what we ask for when praying for his kingdom. His majesty saw that, unless he enabled us to do so by giving us his kingdom here on earth, our natural defects would render us unfit either to hallow, praise, magnify, glorify, or extol the holy name of the eternal Father. Therefore the good Jesus placed the two petitions close together. I will tell you what I understand about the matter, so that you may realize for what you are praying, how important it is to ask for it, and how we should strive to please him who can bestow it.

Among the many other joys of the kingdom of heaven the principal appears to me to consist in a disregard of all earthly things and a peace and beatitude which rejoice and delight in the bliss of one's companions. The soul dwells in perfect peace and feels supreme satisfaction at seeing that all those around it honour and praise God and bless his name, and at knowing that they never offend him. In heaven every one loves him; the soul cares for nothing but loving him: it cannot cease to do so because it knows him as he is. If only we knew him we should love him in the same way in this world, and although not so constantly and so perfectly as in heaven, yet very differently from what we do now.

Responsorial.

R: He who can give good things to his children urges us to ask, to seek and to knock. * The more loyal our faith, the stronger our hope and the more ardent our desire, so much the more shall we receive.

V: In this matter of prayer more is obtained by sighs than by speech, more by tears than by words.

R: The more loyal our faith, the stronger our hope and the more ardent our desire, so much the more shall we receive.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jb. 3: 1 – 26*

Lamentations of Job.

After this Job opened his mouth and cursed the day of his birth. And Job said: "Let the day perish wherein I was born, and the night which said, 'A man-child is conceived.' Let that day be darkness! May God above not seek it, nor light shine upon it. Let gloom and deep darkness claim it. Let clouds dwell upon it; let the blackness of the day terrify it. That night – let thick darkness seize it! Let it not rejoice among the days of the year; let it not come into the number of the months. Yes, let that night be barren; let no joyful cry be heard in it.

Let those curse it who curse the day, who are skilled to rouse up Levi'athan. Let the stars of its dawn be dark; let it hope for light, but have none, nor see the eyelids of the morning; because it did not shut the doors of my mother's womb, nor hide trouble from my eyes.

"Why did I not die at birth, come forth from the womb and expire? Why did knees receive me? or why breasts, that I should suck? For then I should have lain down and been quiet; I should have slept; then I should have been at rest, with kings and counsellors of the earth who rebuilt ruins for themselves, or with princes who had gold, who filled their houses with silver.

Or why was I not as a hidden untimely birth, as infants that never see the light? There the wicked cease from troubling, and there the weary are at rest. There the prisoners are at ease together; they hear not the voice of the taskmaster.

The small and the great are there, and the slave is free from his master. "Why is light given to him that is in misery, and life to the bitter in soul, who long for death, but it comes not, and dig for it more than for hid

treasures; who rejoice exceedingly, and are glad, when they find the grave? Why is light given to a man whose way is hid, whom God has hedged in?

For my sighing comes as my bread, and my groanings are poured out like water. For the thing that I fear comes upon me, and what I dread befalls me. I am not at ease, nor am I quiet; I have no rest; but trouble comes."

Responsorial. *Cfr. Jb. 3: 24-26; 6: 13*

R: In the place of food my groans enter into me, and my cries rise like water: that which I fear befalls me, and what terrifies me overcomes me. *
Lord, your anger weighs heavily on me.

V: Is there no help for me? Even my closest friends have gone far away from me!

R: Lord, your anger weighs heavily on me.

Second Reading. *Book 10: 1, 1- 2, 2 ,5,7*

You, Lord, know everything about man, because you have created him.

A reading from the "Confessions" of St. Augustine, bishop.

Let me know You, O You who know me; let me know You, as I am known. O You strength of my soul, enter into it, and prepare it for Yourself, that You may have and hold it without "spot or wrinkle." This is my hope, "therefore have I spoken;" and in this hope do I rejoice, when I rejoice soberly. Other things of this life ought the less to be sorrowed for, the more they are sorrowed for; and ought the more to be sorrowed for, the less men do sorrow for them. For behold, "You desire truth," seeing that he who does it "comes to the light." This I wish to do in confession in my heart before You, and in my writing before many witnesses.

And from You, O Lord, unto whose eyes the depths of man's conscience are naked, what in me could be hidden though I were unwilling to confess to You? For so should I hide You from myself, not myself from You. But now, because my groaning witnesses that I am dissatisfied with myself, You shine forth, and satisfy, and are beloved and desired; that I may blush for myself, and renounce myself, and choose You, and may neither please You nor myself, except in You. To You, then, O Lord, am I manifest, whatever I am, and with what fruit I may confess unto You I have spoken. Nor do I do it with words and sounds of the flesh, but with the words of the soul, and that cry of reflection that Your ear knows. For when I am wicked,

to confess to You is naught but to be dissatisfied with myself; but when I am truly devout, it is naught but not to attribute it to myself, because You, O Lord, “bless the righteous”, but first You justify him “ungodly.” My confession, therefore, O my God, in Your sight, is made unto You silently, and yet not silently. For in noise it is silent, in affection it cries aloud. For neither do I give utterance to anything that is right unto men which You have not heard from me before, nor do You hear anything of the kind from me which You Yourself have not first said to me.

For it is You, Lord, that judge me;” for although no “man knows the things of a man, save the spirit of man which is in him,” yet is there something of man which “the spirit of man which is in him” itself knows not. But You, Lord, who have made him, knows him wholly. I indeed, though in Your sight I despise myself, and reckon “myself but dust and ashes,” ‘yet I know something concerning You, which I know not concerning myself. And assuredly “now we see through a glass darkly,” not yet “face to face.” So long, therefore, as I be “absent” from You, I am more “present” with myself than with You;’ and yet I know that You cannot suffer violence; but **for myself I know not what temptations I am able to resist, and what I am not able.** But there is hope, because You are faithful, who will not suffer us to be tempted above that we are able, but will with the temptation also make a way to escape, that we may be able to bear it. I would therefore confess what I know concerning myself; I will confess also what I know not concerning myself. And because what I do know of myself, I know by You enlightening me; and what I know not of myself, so long I know not until the time when my “darkness be as the noonday” in Your sight.

Responsorial. *Ps. 138: 1, 2, 7*

R: Lord, you scrutinize me and you know me; * you penetrate my thoughts from afar.

V: Where can I go far from your spirit, where can I flee from your presence?

R: You penetrate my thoughts from afar.

Gospel. *Mt. 11: 20 – 24*

Tyre and Sidon on the day of Judgement will have a lighter sentence than yours.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Then he began to upbraid the cities where most of his mighty works had been done, because they did not repent. "Woe to you, Chora'zin! woe to you, Beth-sa'ida! for if the mighty works done in you had been done in Tyre and Sidon, they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes. But I tell you, it shall be more tolerable on the Day of Judgment for Tyre and Sidon than for you.

And you, Caper'na-um, will you be exalted to heaven? You shall be brought down to Hades. For if the mighty works done in you had been done in Sodom, it would have remained until this day. But I tell you that it shall be more tolerable on the Day of Judgment for the land of Sodom than for you."

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Sam. 6: 1 – 23*

The Ark of the Covenant is transported to Jerusalem.

A reading from the second book of Samuel.

David again gathered all the chosen men of Israel, thirty thousand. And David arose and went with all the people who were with him from Ba'ale-judah, to bring up from there the ark of God, which is called by the name of the LORD of hosts who sits enthroned on the cherubim.

And they carried the ark of God upon a new cart, and brought it out of the house of Abin'adab that was on the hill; and Uzzah and Ahi'o, the sons of Abin'adab, were driving the new cart with the ark of God; and Ahi'o went before the ark. And David and all the house of Israel were making merry before the LORD with all their might, with songs and lyres and harps and tambourines and castanets and cymbals. And when they came to the threshing floor of Nacon, Uzzah put out his hand to the ark of God and took hold of it, for the oxen stumbled. And the anger of the LORD was kindled against Uzzah; and God smote him there because he put forth his hand to the ark; and he died there beside the ark of God. And David was angry because the LORD had broken forth upon Uzzah; and that place is called Pe'rez-uz'zah, to this day. And David was afraid of the LORD that day; and he said, "How can the ark of the LORD come to me?" So David was not willing to take the ark of the LORD into the city of David; but David took it aside to the house of O'bed-e'dom the Gittite. And the ark of the LORD remained in the house of O'bed-e'dom the Gittite three months; and the LORD blessed O'bed-e'dom and all his household.

And it was told King David, "The LORD has blessed the household of O'bed-e'dom and all that belongs to him, because of the ark of God." So David went and brought up the ark of God from the house of O'bed-e'dom to the city of David with rejoicing; and when those who bore the ark of the LORD had gone six paces, he sacrificed an ox and a fatling. And David danced before the LORD with all his might; and David was girded with a linen ephod. So David and all the house of Israel brought up the ark of the LORD with shouting, and with the sound of the horn. As the ark of the

LORD came into the city of David, Michal the daughter of Saul looked out of the window, and saw King David leaping and dancing before the LORD; and she despised him in her heart. And they brought in the ark of the LORD, and set it in its place, inside the tent that David had pitched for it; and David offered burnt offerings and peace offerings before the LORD. And when David had finished offering the burnt offerings and the peace offerings, he blessed the people in the name of the LORD of hosts, and distributed among all the people, the whole multitude of Israel, both men and women, to each a cake of bread, a portion of meat, and a cake of raisins. Then all the people departed, each to his house. And David returned to bless his household. But Michal the daughter of Saul came out to meet David, and said, "How the king of Israel honoured himself today, uncovering himself today before the eyes of his servants' maids, as one of the vulgar fellows shamelessly uncovers himself!" And David said to Michal, "It was before the LORD, who chose me above your father, and above all his house, to appoint me as prince over Israel, the people of the LORD -- and I will make merry before the LORD. I will make myself yet more contemptible than this, and I will be abased in your eyes; but by the maids of whom you have spoken, by them I shall be held in honour." And Michal the daughter of Saul had no child to the day of her death.

Responsorial. *Ps. 131: 8-9; Ps. 23: 7*

R: Rise up, Lord to the place of your rest, you and the ark of your power. *
Let the priests clothe themselves with justice, let the faithful sing for joy.

V: Gates, lift up your heads; raise yourselves up, ancient doors: let the king of glory enter.

R: Let the priests clothe themselves with justice, let the faithful sing for joy.

Second Reading.

I will go to the place of the marvellous tabernacle.

A reading from the "Homily to the neophytes on psalm 41" of St. Jerome, presbyter.

‘Like the deer that yearns for the fountains of water, so my soul is yearning for you, O God’. As those deer, then, yearn for the fountains of water, so it is with our deer: they have come out of Egypt and left the world, they have slain Pharaoh and all his army in the waters of baptism. Now, after slaying the devil, they yearn for the fountains of the Church: the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit.

That the Father is a fountain is related in Jeremiah: ‘They have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water’. We read elsewhere of the Son: ‘They have forsaken the fountain of wisdom’. Again, of the Holy Spirit: ‘Whoever drinks of the water that I shall give him, there will rise up in him a fountain of water welling up to eternal life’. Straightway the evangelist explains that the Saviour was speaking of the Holy Spirit.

These quotations clearly demonstrate that the three fountains of the Church are the mystery of the Trinity.

The soul of the believer, of the baptised person, yearns for these fountains, and he says: ‘My soul has thirsted for God, the living fountain’. His was no mild wish to see God- he yearned with all his ardour, he thirsted with burning passion. Before receiving baptism they spoke with one another and said: ‘When shall I come and appear before the face of God?’ See, what they asked for has come to pass, they have come and stood before the face of God; they have appeared before the altar and the sacred mysteries of the Saviour.

Admitted to the body of Christ and reborn in the life-giving fountain, they speak with confidence and say: ‘I will go to the place of the wonderful tabernacle, even to the house of God’. The house of God is the Church, this is the wonderful tabernacle: for in it is the voice of exultation and praise, and the sound of those who keep festival.

You who have now put on Christ and follow our guidance are like little fish on the hook: you are being pulled up out of the deep waters of this world by the word of God. And so you can say: ‘In us nature is changed’. For fish which are taken out of the sea die; but the apostles have fished and taken us out of the sea of this world in such a way that we have been brought to life from the dead. While we were in the world our eyes were in the depths and our life was spent amidst the mire. When we were snatched from the waves we began to see the sun, we began to gaze upon the true

light, and, troubled with excess of joy, we said to our souls: 'Hope in God, for I shall praise him, my Saviour and my God'.

Responsorial. *Ps. 26: 4*

R: One thing I ask of the Lord, one thing I seek: * That I may dwell in the house of the Lord all the days of my life.

V: One thing I ask: to gaze upon the beauty of the Lord and to seek him in his temple,

R: that I may dwell in the house of the Lord all the days of my life.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jb. 4: 1 – 21*

The discourse of Eliphaz.

A reading from the book of Job.

Then Eli'phaz the Te'manite answered: 'If one ventures a word with you, will you be offended? Yet who can keep from speaking?

Behold, you have instructed many, and you have strengthened the weak hands. Your words have upheld him who was stumbling, and you have made firm the feeble knees. But now it has come to you, and you are impatient; it touches you, and you are dismayed.

Is not your fear of God your confidence, and the integrity of your ways your hope? "Think now, who that was innocent ever perished? Or where was the upright cut off? As I have seen, those who plough iniquity and sow trouble reap the same.

By the breath of God they perish, and by the blast of his anger they are consumed. The roar of the lion, the voice of the fierce lion, the teeth of the young lions, are broken. The strong lion perishes for lack of prey, and the whelps of the lioness are scattered. "Now a word was brought to me stealthily, my ear received the whisper of it.

Amid thoughts from visions of the night, when deep sleep falls on men, dread came upon me, and trembling, which made all my bones shake. A spirit glided past my face; the hair of my flesh stood up. It stood still, but I could not discern its appearance. A form was before my eyes; there was

silence, then I heard a voice: `can mortal man be righteous before God? Can a man be pure before his Maker?

Even in his servants he puts no trust, and his angels he charges with error; how much more those who dwell in houses of clay, whose foundation is in the dust, who are crushed before the moth. Between morning and evening they are destroyed; they perish forever without any regarding it. If their tent-cord is plucked up within them, do they not die, and that without wisdom?'

Responsorial. *Jb. 4: 17-18; Rm. 3: 23, 25*

R: Can a mortal man be just in front of God or can man be innocent in front of his creator? * Even in his servants he puts no trust and his angels he charges with error.

V: All have sinned and fallen short of the glory of God, and are justified freely by his grace.

R: Even in his servants he puts no trust and his angels he charges with error.

Second Reading. *Book 10: 43*

I have thrown on you all my worries, O Lord, in order to have life.

A reading from the “Confessions” of St. Augustine.

But the true Mediator, whom in Your secret mercy You have pointed out to the humble, and did send, that by His example also they might learn the same humility — that “Mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus,” appeared between mortal sinners and the immortal Just One — mortal with men, just with God; that because the reward of righteousness is life and peace, He might, by righteousness conjoined with God, cancel the death of justified sinners, which He willed to have in common with them? Hence He was pointed out to holy men of old; to the intent that they, through faith in His Passion to come,’ even as we through faith in that which is past, might be saved. For as man He was Mediator; but as the Word He was not between, because equal to God, and God with God, and together with the Holy Spirit one God.

How have You loved us, good Father, who spared not Your only Son, but delivered Him up for us wicked ones! How have You loved us, for whom He, who thought it no robbery to be equal with You, “became

obedient unto death, even the death of the cross; He alone “free among the dead,” that had power to lay down His life, and power to take it again; for us was He unto You both Victor and Victim, and the Victor as being the Victim; for us was He unto You both Priest and Sacrifice, and Priest as being the Sacrifice; of slaves making us Your sons, by being born of You, and serving us. Rightly, then, is my hope strongly fixed on Him, that You will heal all my diseases through Him who sits at Your right hand and makes intercession for us; else should I utterly despair? For numerous and great are my infirmities, yes, numerous and great are they; but Your medicine is greater. We might think that Your Word was removed from union with man, and despair of ourselves had He not been “made flesh and dwelt among us.”

Terrified by my sins and the load of my misery, I had resolved in my heart, and meditated flight into the wilderness; but You did forbid me, and did strengthen me, saying, therefore, Christ “died for all, that they who live should not henceforth live unto themselves, but unto Him who died for them.” Behold, O Lord, I cast my care upon You, that I may live, and “behold wondrous things out of Your law.” You know my unskillfulness and my infirmities; teach me, and heal me. Your only Son — He “in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” — has redeemed me with His blood. Let not the proud speak evil of me, because I consider my ransom, and that I eat and drink, and that I seek; the poor, like me desire to be satisfied from Him, together with those who eat and are satisfied, and they praise the Lord that seek him.

Responsorial. *Ps. 93: 22; 117: 14*

R: The Lord is my defence; * my God is the rock of my refuge.

V: My strength and my song is the Lord, he has been my salvation.

R: My God is the rock of my refuge.

Gospel. *Mt. 11: 25 – 27*

You have hidden theses things from the wise and have revealed them to the little ones.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

At that time Jesus declared, "I thank you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, that you have hidden these things from the wise and understanding

and revealed them to babes; yes, Father, for such was your gracious will. My Father has delivered all things to me; and no one knows the Son except the Father, and no one knows the Father except the Son and any one to whom the Son chooses to reveal him.

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Sam. 7: 1 – 25*

Messianic oracle of Nathan.

A reading from the second book of Samuel.

Now when the king dwelt in his house, and the LORD had given him **rest from all his enemies** round about, the king said to Nathan the prophet, "See now, I dwell in a house of cedar, but the ark of God dwells in a tent." And Nathan said to the king, "Go, do all that is in your heart; for the LORD is with you." But that same night the word of the LORD came to Nathan, "Go and tell my servant David, `Thus says the LORD: Would you build me a house to dwell in? I have not dwelt in a house since the day I brought up the people of Israel from Egypt to this day, but I have been moving about in a tent for my dwelling. In all places where I have moved with all the people of Israel, did I speak a word with any of the judges of Israel, whom I commanded to shepherd my people Israel, saying, "Why have you not built me a house of cedar?"

Now therefore thus you shall say to my servant David, `Thus says the LORD of hosts, I took you from the pasture, from following the sheep, that you should be prince over my people Israel; and I have been with you wherever you went, and have cut off all your enemies from before you; and I will make for you a great name, like the name of the great ones of the earth. And I will appoint a place for my people Israel, and will plant them, that they may dwell in their own place, and be disturbed no more; and violent men shall afflict them no more, as formerly, from the time that I appointed judges over my people Israel; and I will give you rest from all your enemies. Moreover the LORD declares to you that the LORD will make you a house. When your days are fulfilled and you lie down with your fathers, I will raise up your offspring after you, who shall come forth from your body, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. I will be his father, and he shall be my son. When he commits iniquity, I will chasten him with the rod of men, with the stripes of the sons of men; but I will not take my steadfast love from him, as I took it from Saul, whom I put away

from before you. And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure for ever before me; your throne shall be established for ever."

In accordance with all these words, and in accordance with all this vision, Nathan spoke to David. Then King David went in and sat before the LORD, and said, "Who am I, O Lord GOD, and what is my house, that you have brought me thus far? And yet this was a small thing in your eyes, O Lord GOD; you have spoken also of your servant's house for a great while to come, and have shown me future generations, O Lord GOD! And what more can David say to you? For you know your servant, O Lord GOD! Because of your promise, and according to your own heart, you have wrought all this greatness, to make your servant know it. Therefore you are great, O LORD God; for there is none like you, and there is no God besides you, according to all that we have heard with our ears. **What other nation on earth is like your people Israel**, whom God went to redeem to be his people, making himself a name, and doing for them great and terrible things, by driving out before his people a nation and its gods? And you did establish for yourself your people Israel to be your people forever; and you, O LORD, did become their God.

And now, O LORD God, confirm forever the word that you have spoken concerning your servant and concerning his house, and do as you have spoken.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Lk. 1: 30-33; Ps. 131: 11*

R: The angel of the Lord said to Mary: You will conceive a son and you will bring him to the light; the Lord will give him the throne of his father David, * and he will reign forever over the house of Jacob.

V: The Lord has sworn an oath to David and he will not go back on his word: I will place the fruit of your womb on your throne;

R: and he will reign forever over the house of Jacob.

Second Reading. *C.XV, 30 – 31*

Jesus Christ born of the race of David according to the flesh.

A reading from the book “On the predestination of the Saints” of St. Augustine, bishop.

The most glorious, the most luminous example of predestination and grace is the Saviour himself, the mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus. What merits, of good deeds or of faith, did his human nature

have beforehand to bring this about? Let us have an answer to this question. How did that man earn the privilege of being assumed into unity of person by the Word co-eternal with the Father, and of being the only-begotten Son of God? Was it because of some good quality that he already possessed? Was there any previous act, any faith, any petition of his, capable of bringing him to this unique dignity? Was it not the Word that brought this about? Was it not by being assumed by the Word that this man, from the time he began to be, began to be the only Son of God?

So then we must discern in our head the very source of grace, from which it flows through all his members in accordance with the capacity of each. **The grace by which that man, from the moment he began to be, became Christ is the grace by which every man, from the moment he begins to believe, becomes a Christian.** It is **of the same spirit that Christ was born and the Christian reborn; it is through the same Spirit that we have our sins forgiven and that he was without sin.** God certainly knew that he would do these things. Hence this is the predestination of the saints, and it was exemplified with the greatest clarity in the case of **the Saint of saints**. Can any man who rightly understands the utterances of the truth deny this predestination, seeing that we have learned that the Lord of glory himself was predestined, in as much as a man became the Son of God?

And so Jesus was predestined, so that he who was to be the son of David according to the flesh should nevertheless be the Son of God in power according to the Spirit of holiness; for he was born of the Holy Spirit and of the Virgin Mary. Thus, in a unique and inexpressible way a man was assumed by God the Word and so could truly and properly be called at once Son of God and son of man: son of man because of the man assumed, Son of God because of the only-begotten God who assumed. Otherwise we should believe not in the Trinity but in a Quaternity.

So great, so lofty, so sublime is this exaltation to which human nature was predestined that it could be raised to no greater heights. So too the very Godhead could empty itself in no greater humility for us than by taking on man's nature with its human weakness, even to the point of death on the cross. As he, the one, was predestined to be our head, so we, the many, were predestined to be his members. Let man's merits be silent here – they died in Adam; let God's grace reign, the grace which reigns through Jesus Christ, the only Son of God, the one Lord. If any man can find in our head the

merits that preceded his unique birth, he may look in us the members for the merits that precede our multiplied rebirth.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Gal. 4: 4-5; Ep. 2: 4; Rm. 8: 3*

R: Behold, the appointed time is here: God has sent his own Son into the world, born of a woman, born under the law, * to redeem those under the law.

V: For the great love he bore us, God sent his own Son in the likeness of human flesh,

R: to redeem those under the law.

CYCLE 2

First Reading *Jb. 5: 1 – 27*

Do not scorn the correction of the Lord.

Eliphaz said: "Call now; is there any one who will answer you? To which of the holy ones will you turn? Surely vexation kills the fool, and jealousy slays the simple. I have seen the fool taking root, but suddenly I cursed his dwelling. His sons are far from safety, they are crushed in the gate, and there is no one to deliver them. His harvest the hungry eat, and he takes it even out of thorns; and the thirsty pant after his wealth.

For affliction does not come from the dust, nor does trouble sprout from the ground; but man is born to trouble as the sparks fly upward. "As for me, I would seek God, and to God would I commit my cause; who does great things and unsearchable, marvellous things without number: he gives rain upon the earth and sends waters upon the fields; he sets on high those who are lowly, and those who mourn are lifted to safety. He frustrates the devices of the crafty, so that their hands achieve no success. He takes the wise in their own craftiness; and the schemes of the wily are brought to a quick end. They meet with darkness in the daytime, and grope at noonday as in the night. But he saves the fatherless from their mouth, the needy from the hand of the mighty. So the poor have hope, and injustice shuts her mouth. "Behold, happy is the man whom God reproves; therefore despise not the chastening of the Almighty. For he wounds, but he binds up; he smites, but his hands heal.

He will deliver you from six troubles; in seven there shall no evil touch you. In famine he will redeem you from death, and in war from the power of the sword. You shall be hid from the scourge of the tongue, and shall not fear destruction when it comes. At destruction and famine you shall laugh, and shall not fear the beasts of the earth. For you shall be in league with the stones of the field, and the beasts of the field shall be at peace with you.

You shall know that your tent is safe, and you shall inspect your fold and miss nothing. You shall know also that your descendants shall be many, and your offspring as the grass of the earth. You shall come to your grave in ripe old age, as a shock of grain comes up to the threshing floor in its season. Lo, this we have searched out; it is true. Hear, and know it for your good."

Responsorial *Jb. 5: 17- 18; Ap. 3: 19*

R: Happy is the man who is corrected by God: therefore do not disdain the correction of the Almighty; * because he wounds but he binds up, he smites, but his hands heal.

V: All those whom I love I rebuke and I punish. Show yourself therefore to be zealous and convert.

R: because he wounds but he binds up, he smites, but his hands heal.

Second Reading *Book 11: 1, 1 – 2, 3*

*That I may be able to offer myself in sacrifice
the service of my thought and my word.*

A reading from the “Confessions” of St. Augustine, bishop

O LORD since eternity is Yours, are You ignorant of the things that I say unto You? Or do You see at the time that which comes to pass in time? Why, therefore, do I place before You so many relations of things? Not surely that You might know them through me, but that I may awaken my own love and that of my readers towards You, that we may all say, “Great is the Lord, and greatly to be praised.” I have already said, and shall say, for the love of Your love I do this. For we also pray, and yet Truth says, “Your Father knows what things you have need of before you ask Him.”

Therefore do we make known unto You our love, in confessing unto You our own miseries and Your mercies upon us, that You may free us altogether, since You have begun, that we may cease to be wretched in

ourselves, and that we may be blessed in You; since You have called us, that we may be poor in spirit, and meek, and mourners, and hungering and athirst after righteousness, and merciful, and pure in heart, and peacemakers? Behold, I have told you many things, which I could and which I would, for You first wanted that I should confess unto You, the Lord my God, for You are good, since Your “mercy endures for ever.”

But when shall I suffice with the tongue of my pen to express all Your exhortations, and all Your terrors, and comforts, and guidance, whereby You have led me to preach Your Word and to dispense Your Sacrament unto Your people? And if I suffice to utter these things in order, the drops of time are dear to me. Long have I burned to meditate in Your law, and in it to confess to You my knowledge and ignorance, the beginning of Your enlightening, and the remains of your darkness, until infirmity be swallowed up by strength. And I would not that to ought else those hours should flow away, which I find free from the necessities of refreshing my body, and the care of my mind, and of the service which we owe to men, and which, though we owe not, even yet we pay.’

O Lord my God, hear my prayer, and let Your mercy regard my longing, since it burns not for myself alone, but because it desires to benefit brotherly charity; and You see into my heart, that so it is. I would sacrifice to You the service of my thought and tongue; and do You give what I may offer unto You. For “I am poor and needy,” You reach unto all that call upon You? You who free from cares, care for us. Circumcise from all rashness and from all lying my inward and outward lips. Let Your Scriptures be my chaste delights. Neither let me be deceived in them, nor deceive out of them. Lord, hear and pity, O Lord my God, light of the blind, and strength of the weak; even also light of those that see, and strength of the strong, hearken unto my soul, and hear it crying “out of the depths.”

Responsorial *Ps. 60: 2-3, 6*

R: Listen, O God, to my cry, be attentive to my prayer. * From the ends of the earth I invoke you;

V: because you, God, have listened to my vows, you have given me the inheritance of the one who fears your name.

R: From the ends of the earth I invoke you.

Gospel *Mt. 11: 28 – 30*

I am meek and humble of heart.

Come to me, all who labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take my **yoke** upon you, and **learn** from me; for I am **gentle** and **lowly** in heart, and you will find **rest** for your souls. For my yoke is **easy**, and my burden is **light**."

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Sam. 11: 1 – 17, 26 – 27*

The sin of David.

A reading from the second book of Samuel.

In the spring of the year, the time when kings go forth to battle, David sent Jo'ab, and his servants with him, and all Israel; and they ravaged the Ammonites, and besieged Rabbah. But David remained at Jerusalem. It happened, late one afternoon, when David arose from his couch and was walking upon the roof of the king's house that he saw from the roof a woman bathing; and the woman was very beautiful. And David sent and inquired about the woman. And one said, "Is not this Bathshe'ba, the daughter of Eli'am, the wife of Uri'ah the Hittite?" So David sent messengers, and took her; and she came to him, and he lay with her. (Now she was purifying herself from her uncleanness.) Then she returned to her house.

And the woman conceived; and she sent and told David, "I am with child." So David sent word to Jo'ab, "Send me Uri'ah the Hittite." And Jo'ab sent Uri'ah to David. When Uri'ah came to him, David asked how Jo'ab was doing, and how the people fared, and how the war prospered. Then David said to Uri'ah, "Go down to your house, and wash your feet." And Uri'ah went out of the king's house, and there followed him a present from the king. But Uri'ah slept at the door of the king's house with all the servants of his lord, and did not go down to his house. When they told David, "Uri'ah did not go down to his house," David said to Uri'ah, "Have you not come from a journey? Why did you not go down to your house?" Uri'ah said to David, "The ark and Israel and Judah dwell in booths; and my lord Jo'ab and the servants of my lord are camping in the open field; shall I then go to my house, to eat and to drink, and to lie with my wife? As you live, and as your soul lives, I will not do this thing." Then David said to Uri'ah, "Remain here today also, and tomorrow I will let you depart." So Uri'ah remained in Jerusalem that day, and the next. And David invited him, and he ate in his presence and drank, so that he made him drunk; and in the

evening he went out to lie on his couch with the servants of his lord, but he did not go down to his house.

In the morning David wrote a letter to Jo'ab, and sent it by the hand of Uri'ah. In the letter he wrote, "Set Uri'ah in the forefront of the hardest fighting, and then draw back from him, that he may be struck down, and die." And as Jo'ab was besieging the city, he assigned Uri'ah to the place where he knew there were valiant men. And the men of the city came out and fought with Jo'ab; and some of the servants of David among the people fell. Uri'ah the Hittite was slain also. When the wife of Uri'ah heard that Uri'ah her husband was dead, she made lamentation for her husband. And when the mourning was over, David sent and brought her to his house, and she became his wife, and bore him a son. But the thing that David had done displeased the LORD.

Responsorial. *cfr. 2 Sam. 12: 9; Ex. 20: 2, 13, 14*

R: You have struck Uriah the Hittite with the sword, and you have taken his wife. * Why have you despised the word of the Lord, doing that which is evil in his sight?

V: I am the Lord, your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt. You shall not kill, you shall not commit adultery.

R: Why have you despised the word of the Lord, doing that which is evil in his sight?

Second Reading. *Cat. 1: 2 – 3, 5 – 6*

Convert in the favourable time.

A reading from the “Catechesis” of St. Cyril of Jerusalem, bishop.

If any here is a slave of sin, let him promptly prepare himself through faith for the new birth into freedom and adoption; and having put off the miserable bondage of his sins, and taken on him the most blessed bondage of the Lord, so may he be counted worthy to inherit the kingdom of heaven. Put off, by confession, the old man, which waxes corrupt after the lusts of deceit, that you may put on the new man, which is renewed according to knowledge of Him that created him. Acquire the pledge of the Holy Spirit through faith, that you may be received into the everlasting habitations. Come for the mystical Seal, that you may be easily recognized by the

Master; and be numbered among the holy and spiritual flock of Christ, to be set apart on His right hand, and inherit the life prepared for you.

For they to whom the rough garment of their sins still clings are found on the left hand, because they came not to the grace of God which is given through Christ at the new birth of Baptism: new birth I mean not of bodies, but the spiritual new birth of the soul. For our bodies are begotten by parents who are seen, but our souls are begotten anew through faith: for the Spirit blows where it likes: and then, if you be found worthy, you may hear: Well done, good and faithful servant, when you are found to have no defilement of hypocrisy in your conscience.

For if any of those who are present should think to tempt God's grace, he deceives himself, and knows not its power. Keep your soul free from hypocrisy, O man, because of Him who searches hearts and minds.

The present is the season of confession: confess what you have done in word or in deed, by night or by day; confess in an acceptable time, and in the day of salvation receive the heavenly treasure.

Cleanse your vessel that you may receive grace more abundantly. For though remission of sins is given equally to all, the communion of the Holy Spirit is bestowed in proportion to each man's faith. If you have laboured little, you will receive little; but if you have wrought much, the reward is great. You are running for yourself, see to your own interest.

If you have anything against any man, forgive it: you come here to receive forgiveness of sins, and you also must forgive him that has sinned against you.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Prv. 28: 13; Jn. 1: 9*

R: He who hides his own sins will not prosper. * He who confesses himself a sinner and who abstains from evil, will find indulgence.

V: If we recognize our sins, God who is faithful and just will pardon us.

R: He who confesses himself a sinner and who abstains from evil, will find indulgence.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jb. 6: 1 – 30*

The answer of Job afflicted and abandoned by God.

A reading from the book of Job.

Then Job answered: "O that my vexation were weighed, and all my calamity laid in the balances! For then it would be heavier than the sand of the sea; therefore my words have been rash. For the arrows of the Almighty are in me; my spirit drinks their poison; the terrors of God are arrayed against me.

Does the wild ass bray when he has grass, or the ox low over his fodder? Can that which is tasteless be eaten without salt, or is there any taste in the slime of the mauve water? My appetite refuses to touch them; they are as food that is loathsome to me. "O that I might have my request, and that God would grant my desire; that it would please God to crush me, that he would let loose his hand and cut me off! This would be my consolation; I would even exult in pain unsparing; for I have not denied the words of the Holy One.

What is my strength that I should wait? And what is my end, that I should be patient? Is my strength the strength of stones, or is my flesh bronze? In truth I have no help in me, and any resource is driven from me. "He who withholds kindness from a friend forsakes the fear of the Almighty.

My brethren are treacherous as a torrent-bed, as freshets that pass away, which are dark with ice, and where the snow hides itself. In time of heat they disappear; when it is hot, they vanish from their place. The caravans turn aside from their course; they go up into the waste, and perish. The caravans of Tema look, the travellers of Sheba hope. They are disappointed because they were confident; they come thither and are confounded.

Such you have now become to me; you see my calamity, and are afraid. Have I said, 'Make me a gift'? Or, 'From your wealth offer a bribe for me'? Or, 'Deliver me from the adversary's hand'? Or, 'Ransom me from the hand of oppressors'?

"Teach me, and I will be silent; make me understand how I have erred. How forceful are honest words! But what does reproof from you reprove? Do you think that you can reprove words, when the speech of a despairing man is wind? You would even cast lots over the fatherless, and bargain over your friend. "But now, be pleased to look at me; for I will not lie to your face. Turn, I pray, let no wrong be done. Turn now, my vindication is at stake. Is there any wrong on my tongue? Cannot my taste discern calamity?

Responsorial. *Jb. 6: 2, 3, 13*

R: O that my vexations were weighed, and all my calamities laid in the balance! * My words have been rash, for the arrows of the Almighty are in me.

V: Is there no help for me? Is every resource driven away from me?

R: My words have been rash, for the arrows of the Almighty are in me.

Second Reading. *Book. 11:6*

“Courage, it is I”

A reading from the “Commentary on Matthew” of Origen, presbyter.

If when we are subjected to the danger of temptations, let us remember that the Lord has obliged us to embark, because he wants us to precede him to the other shore! It is impossible for the one who has not borne the trial of the waves and of the wind that is against him to reach the other shore.

Therefore when we see ourselves encircled by numerous difficulties, and tired we find ourselves immersed in them, we think that our boat is in the midst of the sea, shaken by the waves, that want to see us fail in the faith or in some other virtue. If therefore the breath of the enemy persists against us, we think that we have the wind against us.

When in the midst of these sufferings we will have passed the three hours of the dark night, exactly the moments of temptations, fighting in the best possible way and keeping ourselves on the look out in order to avoid the shipwreck of the faith, we are certain that at the arrival of the fourth hour, when “the night is advanced and the day is at hand” (Rm. 13: 12) the Son of God will draw near to us walking on the sea in order to render us tranquil.

When we will see the Word appear to us we will be frightened, to the point that we will not understand that it is the Saviour who has come to stay with us; and believing that we are seeing a ghost, frightened we will cry out; but immediately he will speak to us and he will say to us: “Courage it is I, do not fear” (Mt. 14: 27).

Moved by these words, perhaps there will be found amongst us, more ardent than the others, a Peter who is in journey towards perfection, but who has not yet reached it; he will jump out of the boat, as if fleeing from the trials that threaten him, and at the beginning, in his desire to go to Jesus,

he will walk on the water, but his faith still being insufficient and he himself insecure, feeling the violence of the wind he will be afraid and he will begin to sink. Yet this will not happen, because he will invoke Jesus crying out strongly: "Lord, save me!" (Mt. 14: 30). And Peter has not yet finished saying: "Lord, save me" when the Word extends his hand and helps him, grasping him exactly in the moment in which he is about to sink, and he rebukes him for his little faith and his doubts. Take note above all that he does not call him disbelieving, but "man of little faith"; and he says to him. "Why did you doubt?" (Mt. 14: 31), as one who though having a little faith, hesitates and behaves in the opposite way. Then Jesus and Peter got into the boat, the wind ceased and the passengers, seeing from what danger they had been saved, adore him saying: "You are truly the Son of God" (Mt. 14: 33).

Responsorial. *Ps. 68: 2, 18-19*

R: Save me, O God, the water reaches to my throat. * Do not hide your face from your servant, I am in danger, answer me soon.

V: Draw near to me, ransom me, save me from my enemies.

R: Do not hide your face from your servant, I am in danger, answer me soon.

Gospel. *Mt. 12: 1 – 8*

The Son of Man is Lord of the Sabbath

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

At that time Jesus went through the grain fields on the Sabbath; his disciples were hungry, and they began to pluck heads of grain and to eat. But when the Pharisees saw it, they said to him, "Look, your disciples are doing what is not lawful to do on the Sabbath." He said to them, "Have you not read what David did, when he was hungry, and those who were with him: how he entered the house of God and ate the bread of the Presence, which it was not lawful for him to eat nor for those who were with him, but only for the priests? Or have you not read in the law how on the Sabbath the priests in the temple profane the Sabbath, and are guiltless? I tell you, something greater than the temple is here. And if you had known what this means, 'I desire mercy, and not sacrifice,' you would not have condemned the guiltless. For the Son of man is lord of the Sabbath."

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Sam. 12:1 – 25*

The penance of David.

A reading from the second book of Samuel.

And the LORD sent Nathan to David. He came to him, and said to him, "There were two men in a certain city, the one rich and the other poor. The rich man had very many flocks and herds; but the poor man had nothing but one little ewe lamb, which he had bought. And he brought it up, and it grew up with him and with his children; it used to eat of his morsel, and drink from his cup, and lie in his bosom, and it was like a daughter to him. Now there came a traveller to the rich man, and he was unwilling to take one of his own flock or herd to prepare for the wayfarer who had come to him, but he took the poor man's lamb, and prepared it for the man who had come to him." Then David's anger was greatly kindled against the man; and he said to Nathan, "As the LORD lives, the man who has done this deserves to die; and he shall restore the lamb fourfold, because he did this thing, and because he had no pity." Nathan said to David, "You are the man. Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, 'I anointed you king over Israel, and I delivered you out of the hand of Saul; and I gave you your master's house, and your master's wives into your bosom, and gave you the house of Israel and of Judah; and if this were too little, I would add to you as much more. Why have you despised the word of the LORD, to do what is evil in his sight? You have smitten Uri'ah the Hittite with the sword, and have taken his wife to be your wife, and have slain him with the sword of the Ammonites. Now therefore the sword shall never depart from your house, because you have despised me, and have taken the wife of Uri'ah the Hittite to be your wife.' Thus says the LORD, 'Behold, I will raise up evil against you out of your own house; and I will take your wives before your eyes, and give them to your neighbour, and he shall lie with your wives in the sight of this sun. For you did it secretly; but I will do this thing before all Israel, and before the sun.'"

David said to Nathan, "I have sinned against the LORD." And Nathan said to David, "The LORD also has put away your sin; you shall not die.

Nevertheless, because by this deed you have utterly scorned the LORD, the child that is born to you shall die." Then Nathan went to his house. And the LORD struck the child that Uri'ah's wife bore to David, and it became sick. David therefore besought God for the child; and David fasted, and went in and lay all night upon the ground. And the elders of his house stood beside him, to raise him from the ground; but he would not, nor did he eat food with them. On the seventh day the child died. And the servants of David feared to tell him that the child was dead; for they said, "Behold, while the child was yet alive, we spoke to him, and he did not listen to us; how then can we say to him the child is dead? He may do himself some harm." But when David saw that his servants were whispering together, David perceived that the child was dead; and David said to his servants, "Is the child dead?" They said, "He is dead." Then David arose from the earth, and washed, and anointed himself, and changed his clothes; and he went into the house of the LORD, and worshiped; he then went to his own house; and when he asked, they set food before him, and he ate. Then his servants said to him, "What is this thing that you have done? You fasted and wept for the child while it was alive; but when the child died, you arose and ate food." He said, "While the child was still alive, I fasted and wept; for I said, 'Who knows whether the LORD will be gracious to me, that the child may live?' But now he is dead; why should I fast? Can I bring him back again? I shall go to him, but he will not return to me." Then David comforted his wife, Bathshe'ba, and went in to her, and lay with her; and she bore a son, and he called his name Solomon. And the LORD loved him, and sent a message by Nathan the prophet; so he called his name Jedidi'ah, because of the LORD.

Responsorial. *Oraz of Manassah 9. 10. 12; Ps. 50: 5, 6*

R: My sins are more numerous than the sand of the sea; because of the greatness of my sins I am not worthy to look up to heaven; * I have merited your disdain for the evil that I have committed in front of your eyes.

V: I acknowledge my fault, my sin is always in front of me. Against you alone have I sinned;

R: I have merited your disdain for the evil that I have committed in front of your eyes.

Second Reading. *Disc. 19: 2 – 3*

A contrite spirit is a sacrifice to God.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Augustine, bishop.

‘I acknowledge my transgressions’, says David. If I acknowledge it, then pardon me, O God. We must not assume at all that we are living good lives, free from sin. Let a man’s life be praised in so far as he asks for pardon. But as for men without hope, the less attentive they are to their own sins, the more they pry into those of others. They seek, not what they can correct, but what they can criticize. And as they cannot excuse themselves, they are ready to accuse others. This was not the way that David showed us how to pray and make reparation to God when he said: ‘I acknowledge my transgression, and my sin is always before me’. David was not interested in other men’s sins. He turned his mind to himself, not in self-flattery, but in entering deeply within himself. He did not spare himself, and so it was not presumptuous of him to pray that he might be spared.

Do you want to be reconciled with God? Learn how to act towards yourself, that God may be reconciled with you. Notice what you read in the same psalm: ‘If you wanted sacrifice, I would offer it; you take no pleasure in burnt offerings’. Will you then have no sacrifice? Will you offer nothing, not propitiate God with any offering at all? What have you said? ‘If you wanted sacrifice, I would offer it; you take no pleasure in burnt offerings’. Go on with the psalm, listen, and say: ‘The sacrifice acceptable to God is a broken spirit: a broken and contrite heart he does not despise’. Having abandoned your former offerings, you have found what to offer. Among those of old you used to offer victims from the herds, and they were called sacrifices. ‘If you wanted sacrifice, I would offer it’. Therefore you do not seek those former offerings, and yet you seek a sacrifice.

‘You take no pleasure’, David said, ‘in burnt offerings’. Since you take no pleasure in burnt offerings, will you remain without a sacrifice? Far be it. ‘The sacrifice acceptable to God is a broken spirit, a broken and contrite heart he does not despise’. You have what to offer. Do not examine the flock. Do not prepare ships and penetrate to the most distant provinces to bring back perfumes. Seek in your heart what is acceptable to God. You must rend your heart. Why do you fear that it may perish if it is broken? Here you have these words: ‘Create in me a clean heart, O God’. So then, that a pure heart may be created, let the impure one be broken.

We must be displeased with ourselves when we sin, because sin displeases God. And as we are not without sin, let us at least be like God in

this respect, that what we are displeased with is what displeases him. You are to a certain extent united with the will of God, because you are displeased with what is hateful to him who made you.

Responsorial Ps. 50: 12

R: My sins are embedded like arrows in my flesh. Lord, before they wound me, * heal me with the medicine of repentance.

V: A clean heart create for me, O God. Put a steadfast spirit within me.

R: Heal me with the medicine of repentance.

CYCLE 2

First Reading Jb. 7: 1 – 21

Job oppressed by the tediousness of life cries out against God.

"Has not man a hard service upon earth, and are not his days like the days of a hireling? Like a slave who longs for the shadow, and like a hireling who looks for his wages, so I am allotted months of emptiness, and nights of misery are apportioned to me.

When I lie down I say, 'When shall I arise?' But the night is long, and I am full of tossing till the dawn. My flesh is clothed with worms and dirt; my skin hardens, and then breaks out afresh. My days are swifter than a weaver's shuttle, and come to their end without hope.

"Remember that my life is a breath; my eye will never again see good. The eye of him who sees me will behold me no more; while thy eyes are upon me, I shall be gone. As the cloud fades and vanishes, so he who goes down to Sheol does not come up; he returns no more to his house, nor does his place know him any more.

"Therefore I will not restrain my mouth; I will speak in the anguish of my spirit; I will complain in the bitterness of my soul.

Am I the sea, or a sea monster, that you set a guard over me? When I say, 'My bed will comfort me, my couch will ease my complaint', then you scare me with dreams and terrify me with visions, so that I would choose strangling and death rather than my bones. I loathe my life; I would not live forever. Let me alone, for my days are a breath.

What is man, that you make so much of him, and that you set your mind upon him, you visit him every morning, and test him every moment? How long will you not look away from me, nor let me alone till I swallow my spittle? If I sin, what do I do to you, you watcher of men? Why have you made me your mark? Why have I become a burden to you? Why do you not pardon my transgression and take away my iniquity? For now I shall lie in the earth; you will seek me, but I shall not be."

Responsorial *Cf. Jb. 7: 5, 7, 6*

R: My flesh is covered with worms, and with dirt my skin hardens and breaks out again. * Remember, Lord, that my life is but a breath.

V: My days are swifter than a weaver's shuttle, they are finished without hope.

R: Remember, Lord, that my life is but a breath.

Second Reading *Book 10:26, 37 – 29, 40*

All my hope is placed in your great mercy

A reading from the "Confessions" of St. Augustine, bishop

Where, then, did I find You, so as to be able to know You? For You were not in my memory before I knew You. Where, then, did I find You, so as to be able to know You, but in You above me? Place there is none; we go both "backward" and "forward," and there is no place. Everywhere, O Truth, do You direct all who consult You, and do at once answer all, though they consult You on divers things.

Clearly do You answer, though all do not with clearness hear. All consult You upon whatever they wish, though they hear not always that which they wish. He is Your best servant who does not so much look to hear that from You which he himself wishes, as to wish that which he hears from You.

Too late did I love You, O Fairness, so ancient, and yet so new! Too late did I love You For behold, You were within, and I without, and there did I seek You; I, unlovely, rushed heedlessly among the things of beauty You made.

You were with me, but I was not with You. Those things kept me far from You, which, unless they were in You, were not. You called, and cried aloud, and forced open my deaf ears. You did gleam and shine, and chase

away my blindness. You did exhale odours, and I drew in my breath and do pant after You. I tasted, and do hunger and thirst. You did touch me, and I burned for Your peace.

When I shall cleave unto You with all my being, then shall I in nothing have pain and labour; and my life shall be a real life, being wholly full of You. But now since he whom You fill is the one You lift up, I am a burden to myself, as not being full of You. Joys of sorrow contend with sorrows of joy; and on which side the victory may be I know not.

Woe is me! Lord, have pity on me. My evil sorrows contend with my good joys; and on which side the victory may be I know not. Woe is me! Lord, have pity on me. Woe is me! Lo, I hide not my wounds; You are the Physician, I the sick; You merciful, I miserable. Is not the life of man upon earth a hard labour?' Who is he that wishes for vexations and difficulties? You command them to be endured, not to be loved. For no man loves what he endures, though he may love to endure. For notwithstanding he rejoices to endure, he would rather there were naught for him to endure.' In adversity, I desire prosperity; in prosperity, I fear adversity. What middle place, then, is there between these, where human life is not a hard labour? Woe unto the prosperity of this world, once and again, from fear of misfortune and a corruption of joy!

Woe unto the adversities of this world, once and again, and for the third time, from the desire of prosperity; and because adversity itself is a hard thing, and makes shipwreck of endurance! Is not the life of man upon earth a hard labour, and that without intermission? And my whole hope is only in Your exceeding great mercy.

Responsorial *Cf. St. Augustine, Confess. 10: 27; Lk. 19: 10*

R: Too late have I loved you, beauty so ancient and yet so new! * You have called, you have cried and you have overcome my deafness.

V: The Son of man has come to search for and to save that which was lost.

R: You have called, you have cried and you have overcome my deafness.

Gospel *Mt. 12: 14 – 21*

He ordered them not to spread the news so that what had been said could be fulfilled.

But the Pharisees went out and took counsel against him, how to destroy him. Jesus, aware of this, withdrew from there. And many followed him, and he healed them all, and ordered them not to make him known. This was to fulfil what the prophet Isaiah spoke: "Behold, my servant whom I have chosen, my beloved with whom my soul is well pleased. I will put my Spirit upon him, and he shall proclaim justice to the Gentiles. He will not wrangle or cry aloud, nor will any one hear his voice in the streets; he will not break a bruised reed or quench a smouldering wick, till he brings justice to victory; and in his name will the Gentiles hope."